

Fred Zirbel

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EXPERIENCE

Critical Start

Plano, TX

Principal Security Analyst

July 2026 - Present

- Triage, investigate, and respond to security incidents from detection through resolution across an MDR operation covering 200+ customer environments, correlating evidence from 30+ integrated EDR, SIEM, identity, and network security products to determine scope, root cause, and required containment.
- Analyze endpoint, network, and log data directly within Cortex XDR, CrowdStrike Falcon, Microsoft Defender XDR, and SentinelOne to identify malicious activity and confirm attack techniques across customer environments.
- Execute live containment and remediation actions, including host isolation, credential resets, session revocation, email deletion, and file quarantine, through a dual authorization workflow that removes attacker access and malicious artifacts.
- Communicate investigation findings, response status, and remediation recommendations to customer stakeholders, documenting response actions and incident outcomes during high priority incidents across a 24x7 MDR operation with rotating overnight and weekend shift coverage.
- Maintain a 16 minute average time to investigation while handling 300+ alerts monthly, applying an in-house AI platform across triage, investigation, correlation, and incident documentation while validating all findings against source telemetry.
- Train and mentor L1 analysts on investigation workflow, AI platform usage, and client ready incident documentation.

Senior Security Analyst

July 2025 - July 2026

- Reconstructed attacker activity with custom KQL across endpoint, identity, and email evidence sources, including URL clicks, file downloads, and process telemetry, to establish incident scope and root cause.
- Briefed customer stakeholders during three to five weekly high priority incident calls, communicating findings, attribution, and remediation guidance that informed response decisions.
- Correlated indicators of compromise across customer environments to identify shared phishing and malware campaigns, enabling coordinated response beyond individual alerts.
- Engineered 500+ suppression filters using KVP logic and regex within the MDR detection and orchestration platform, eliminating thousands of recurring false positive alerts and improving analyst signal quality.

Security Analyst

October 2024 - July 2025

- Triaged identity, phishing, malware, and endpoint security alerts across four EDR and SIEM platforms, producing scoped escalations for senior incident responders.
- Developed custom KQL queries across identity, endpoint, and email telemetry in Microsoft Sentinel and Defender to accelerate incident scoping and detection.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

SOC & Incident Response: Alert monitoring and triage, incident investigation and response, threat detection, attack technique analysis, live containment and remediation, incident documentation, customer stakeholder communication, shift based 24x7 MDR operations

EDR & Endpoint Detection: Cortex XDR, CrowdStrike Falcon, Microsoft Defender XDR/Endpoint, SentinelOne

SIEM & Analytics: Microsoft Sentinel, Splunk Enterprise Security, Sumo Logic, KQL, regex, log data analysis

Identity, Cloud & Frameworks: Entra ID, Azure, identity and endpoint telemetry, MITRE ATT&CK, NIST SP 800-61

CERTIFICATIONS

CompTIA SecurityX (CASP+) | CompTIA CySA+ | CompTIA PenTest+ | CompTIA Security+

EDUCATION

Western Governors University

January 2024 - December 2025

Master of Science in Cybersecurity and Information Assurance

The University of Texas at Arlington

August 2019 - December 2023

Bachelor of Science in Information Systems